

Let's try to lay out Sider's reasoning by isolating the various features of the **traditional doctrine** of heaven and hell that he thinks are inconsistent with the existence of a perfectly good God.

“A certain traditional conception of the afterlife is *binary*. After death one proceeds either to heaven or hell. Heaven is very, very good; hell is very, very bad. There are no possibilities for the afterlife other than heaven and hell, and membership in heaven or hell is never indeterminate or a matter of degree. The problem with the binary conception is that it contradicts God's justice. God must employ some criterion to decide who goes to heaven and who goes to hell. No reasonable criterion would be sharp; any reasonable criterion will have borderline cases. But the binary conception of the afterlife allows for no corresponding fuzziness in how the dead are to be treated. Hell must therefore contain people who are nearly indiscernible in relevant respects from people in Heaven. No just God would allow such a monstrously unfair thing.”

It is part of the traditional doctrine that God decides whether people go to heaven and hell based on certain properties of those people. We will leave open for now what those properties might be; just to have a name for them, let's call them the **relevant properties**.

Badness

Dichotomy

Non-
universality

Divine
control

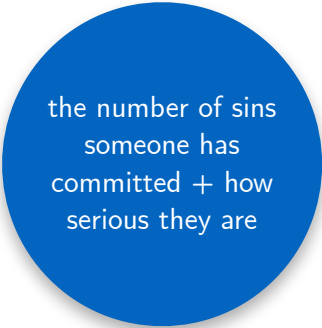
Justice

Proportion- ality

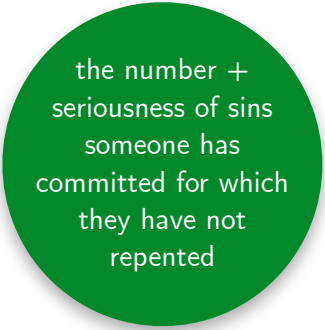
Continuity

A large, solid orange circle is centered on a white background. Inside the circle, the text "the number of sins someone has committed" is written in white, lowercase, sans-serif font, centered horizontally and vertically.

the number of sins
someone has
committed

A solid blue circle with a slight drop shadow, centered on a white background. Inside the circle, the text "the number of sins someone has committed + how serious they are" is written in a white, sans-serif font, arranged in four lines.

the number of sins
someone has
committed + how
serious they are

A solid green circle with a subtle drop shadow, centered on a white background. Inside the circle, the text "the number + seriousness of sins someone has committed for which they have not repented" is written in a white, sans-serif font, arranged in six lines.

the number +
seriousness of sins
someone has
committed for which
they have not
repented



the person's faith and
trust in God

A large, solid purple circle is centered on a white background. Inside the circle, the text "the person's decision to be with God" is written in a white, sans-serif font, centered horizontally and vertically.

the person's decision
to be with God

None of these choices of relevant properties seems to give us a plausible way to deny Continuity.

The core problem seems to be that whatever our choice of relevant properties, the following both seem to be true:

one can have the
property to different
degrees

one can have the
property at some
times but not others



the
paradox of
heaven and
hell



replies to the
paradox

A solid red circle with a soft drop shadow, containing white text.

evil & lives
not worth
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the existence of a perfectly good God.

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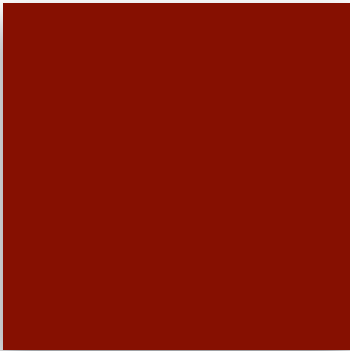


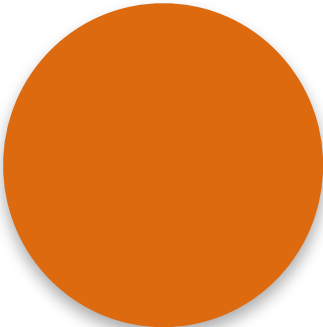


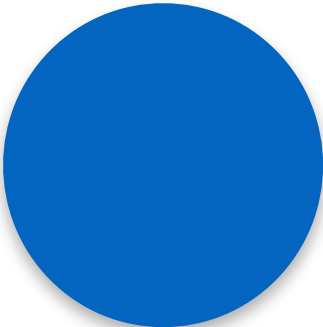


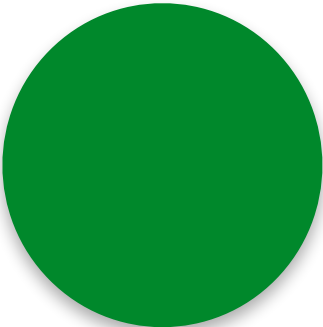


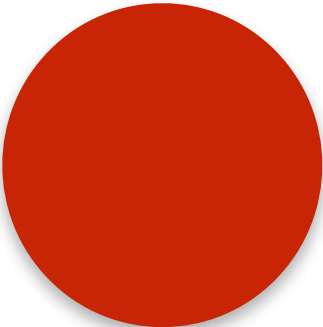












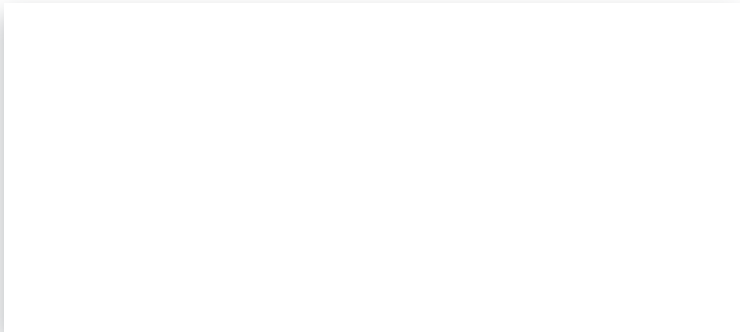


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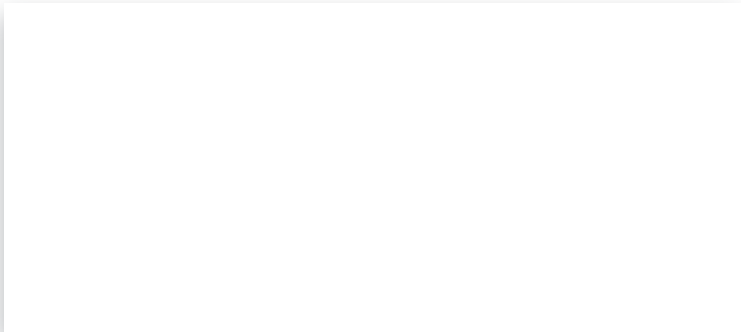




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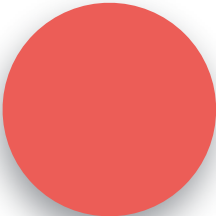


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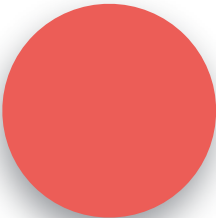






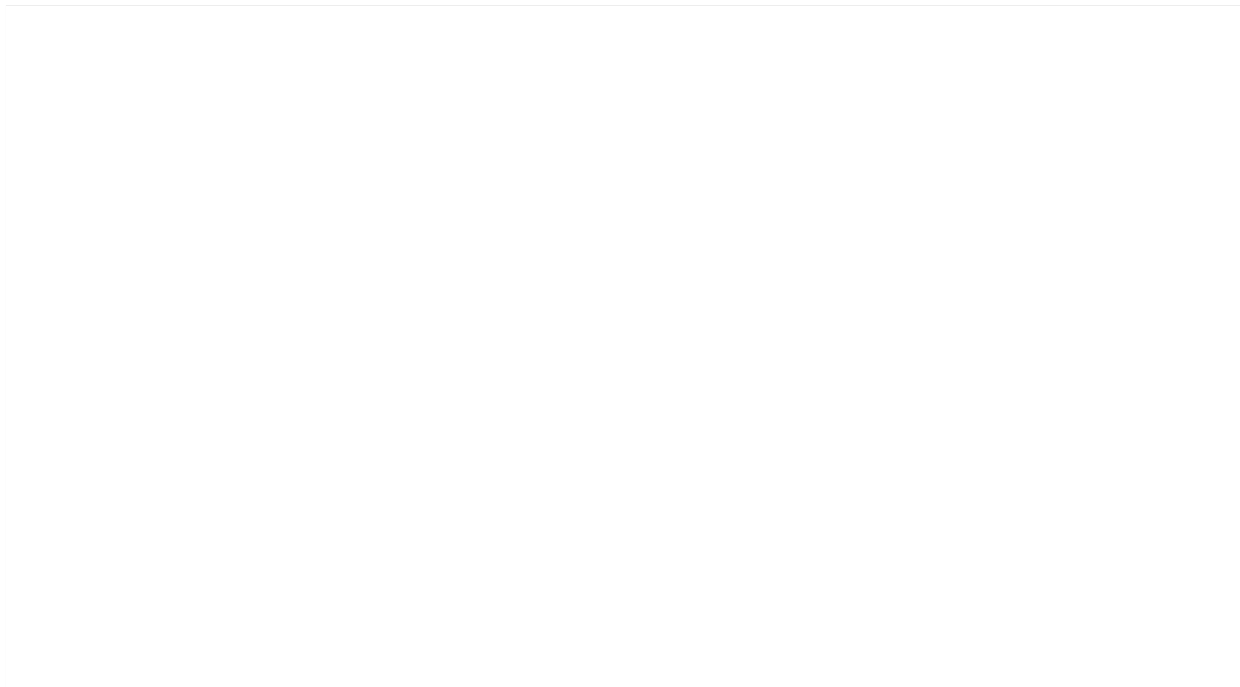
the
paradox of
heaven and
hell





describes the kind of view wanted to discuss:

The following passage from the *Catechism of the Catholic Church*



goats, and he will place the sheep at his right hand,

just and the unjust,' will precede the Last

Judgment. Christ will come "in his glory, and all

all the nations, and he will separate them one from

the angels with him... Before him will be gathered

but the goats at the left.... and they will go away

into external punishment, but the rights into

eternis in die !!

1038. The resurrection of all the dead, 'of both the

another as a shepherd separates the sheep from the

One topic often associated with belief in God is the topic of life after death.

perfectly good Good?

many of the major monotheistic religions compatible with the existence of a

Our first question today is: what we are told about life after death by



this glory, and all the angels with him.

goats, and the wild prairie sheep at his

as a shepherd separates the sheep from the

right hand, but the goat at the left... and

but the rights are all in it.

1038. The reservation of the dead, "of

the Last Judgment. . . Christ will come "in

both the just and the unjust," will proceed

and the wild sheep are then from another

Before him will be gathered all the nations,

they will go away into eternal punishment,

judgment on all of us, and on the basis of our life, decides that some of us will

This certainly seems like a picture according to which, after death, God passes

got to heaven forever, and some others to hell forever. (If not 'forever', then the

talk of the last judgment wouldn't make much sense.)

must depend on the possibility of life after death. We will now ask: is the kind of

Turned-in showed why it is plausible that respo to the argument from evil

view of life after death we get here on pain of being perfectly good?







evil & lives
not worth
living

Badness

Divine
control

Justice

Continuity



It seems difficult to deny Justice, Badness, or Divine Control. So that

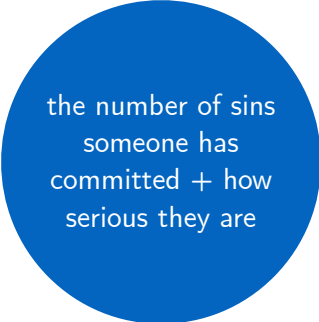
seems to give the defender of the afterlife further main options.



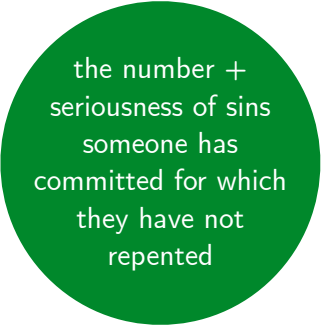
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